week went through to a Grand Final back in Manchester in December. I made it through to that final and it turned out to be a fantastic weekend, for all of us. Mum and Dad stayed with me at the Portland Hotel in the city center. I had my own room, twenty floors up, with this huge plate-glass window overlooking the city below. I think they were a bit nervous about that. On Saturday morning, we had to register and then go over to United's old training ground, the Cliff, for the first part of the competition which was held in the indoor sports hall: ball-juggling, target shooting and short passing. I think I was in the lead already by the time we broke off for lunch.

The second part of the competition was staged out on the field at Old Trafford. I was so nervous I don't think I'd eaten for a couple of days. Mum and Dad were there, probably feeling worse than me. That afternoon, United were playing Spurs, and by the end of the competition there must have been about 40,000 supporters in the ground. I was so excited to be out on that field, I wasn't even thinking about winning. They introduced each of us to the crowd before we did the dribbling and then the long passing. I can still remember when they announced 'David Beckham' and said I was from 'Leytonstone'—all the Tottenham fans started cheering. Then the guy on the microphone said: 'And David is a massive United fan'. All the Spurs fans started jeering and the rest of the ground, the home supporters, began applauding. To be fair, I got a decent reception from both sets of fans when the announcement was made that I'd won.

We went up to the Europa Suite in the main stand where Bobby Charlton was doing the presentation. It was quite an experience for an eleven-year-old. I know Mum and Dad were very proud; people were coming up to them saying how well they thought I'd done. Maybe, though, it didn't overwhelm me completely. I think the function was still going on, but I drifted away into a corner because the game had started and I wanted to watch it on one of the televisions. It had been some afternoon. It was some prize too: a fortnight's training with Barcelona at the Nou Camp in Spain.

I couldn't wait to get over there. Terry Venables was the Barcelona manager, with Mark Hughes and Gary Lineker playing for the team. Me and two other lads were joined by Ray Whelan from the Bobby Charlton Soccer School. The four of us were put up in what looked like a farmhouse—a pretty luxurious one—at the heart of the Nou Camp complex. I think that building had been there even before the soccer club was and you could sense the history of everything that had happened since: there were pennants and memorabilia on the walls, dating way back, alongside pictures of famous players from Barcelona's past. This was a place where legends had been born.